

How to Get Partners to Actually Show Up for Programming

And make it worth their time when they do.

Every talent leader has been there: you put together an excellent program, you make it available, and the partners just don't show up.

This playbook is a practical guide to changing that.

01 Start with the Right Topic

ASK THE PARTNERS WHAT THEY WANT - BUT NOT BY SURVEY

Go to events, social gatherings, and meetings where partners will be. Ask them conversationally.

REFRAME THE QUESTION

Don't ask "What training do you need?" Partners don't think they need training. Instead, try: "What could we do to help you be more valuable to your clients?" Or: "How can we be a better resource for you?"

CONNECT IT TO CLIENTS

The word "client" makes partners' ears perk up in a way that "leadership," "feedback," or "communication" simply don't.

FIND WHAT THEY'RE ANXIOUS ABOUT RIGHT NOW

AI disruption, associate retention, generational workforce changes - find the current sources of anxiety and build programs around them.

GIVE THEM ZERO HOMEWORK

No pre-work. No reading. No survey beforehand. And advertise that in the invite: "No prep required."

02 Optimize the Invite

THE TITLE IS THE WHOLE GAME

If the title doesn't hook them, the rest doesn't matter. You can use AI tools to brainstorm catchy, specific titles, then refine.

FRAME IT AROUND THEIR SELF-INTEREST

We have a program about helping partners work more effectively with the associates they manage. But we don't call it "How to Create a Better Work Environment for Your Associates" (even though that is one of the outcomes). We call it "**How to Get A-Game Performance from Your Associates.**"

ACTIVATE THE COMPETITIVE NERVE

"Partners at other firms are already investing in this skill." That reframes the program from self-improvement (which partners resist) to competitive advantage (which they chase).

PROMISE A TAKEAWAY

"You'll leave with a one-page playbook for your next associate check-in" beats "you'll learn about delegation." Name the artifact in the invite.

NEVER USE THE WORD "TRAINING"

Partners don't think they need to be trained.

03 Get Them in the Door

GET A PARTNER SPONSOR

Find a partner who cares about the topic (you'll know because you asked them in person) and have them co-own it with you. They'll send reminders, drive attendance, and put their reputation behind it.

LEVERAGE THE MANAGING PARTNER - SELECTIVELY

For the programs that really matter, ask the managing partner to personally call or email the management committee. You can't use this lever every time or it loses its power, but for high-investment programs, a personal ask from the MP is transformative.

INCLUDE PARTNERS AS SPEAKERS OR FACILITATORS

If a partner is part of the program, they have a vested interest in high attendance. They'll become your internal marketers. Even minimal involvement works: a partner does the intro, you run the session, the partner joins for Q&A.

BRING IN A FIRM CLIENT

Some of the best partner attendance comes not from a big-name outside speaker, but from a firm client or potential client who happens to be an expert on the topic. Partners will show up when a client is presenting.

USE CLE STRATEGICALLY

Don't just advertise "CLE available." Run a report showing which partners need which credits, then send personalized emails: "You need 3 ethics credits in New York. This program qualifies. It's tomorrow at noon."

SURF EXISTING MEETINGS

Request 10 minutes at the top of a partner meeting that's already on the calendar. You're the opening act. Partners are already there, and once you start, they see the value. This doesn't replace a standalone program, but it's a powerful way to build demand for one.

MAKE IT EXCLUSIVE

"We've invited 15 select partners to join us for this initial pilot." You sometimes get more attendance by inviting fewer people.

MAKE IT OPT-OUT

Register partners automatically and let them opt out if they want. Behavioral economics research shows this can nearly double participation. Bold? Yes. Effective? Also yes. Just something to try.

PUT IT WHERE ATTENDANCE ISN'T OPTIONAL

The retreat. The new partner orientation. The annual partners' meeting. If there's something you really want every partner to experience, embed it somewhere they're already required to be.

GET THE RIGHT PERSON TO DO THE INTRODUCTION

The managing partner or a member of the executive committee introducing the speaker signals that leadership takes this seriously. Include it in the invite: "The managing partner will introduce the session."

SET EXPECTATIONS UPFRONT

If the program will be interactive, say so in the marketing. "Cameras on. There will be call-and-response, real-time input, and breakout discussions." People show up prepared to participate rather than multitask.

PROMISE MULTIPLE WAYS TO CONSUME

Mention micro-learnings, visual one-pagers, and follow-up resources that will come after the program. Partners who can't attend may engage with the follow-up materials, and the knowledge that content will continue beyond a single session gives fence-sitters a reason to start.

04 Make It Worth Their Time

COMMISERATE IMMEDIATELY

Everyone loves having their experience validated or their pain seen. Open with a shared-experience question that requires nothing more than a "yes" in the chat: "Do you ever feel like associates today think about their job differently than you did as an associate? If so, drop a 'yes' in the chat." This also breaks the seal on participation early.

START WITH "ONE WORD"

"Give me one word to describe how you're feeling right now." Then a quick collective deep breath. This brings everyone into the room - especially when they're running in from back-to-back meetings.

OPEN WITH PURPOSE, NOT CONTENT

"Why does this topic matter?" Make it personal. If you're doing a session on feedback: "Think about a time you had to deliver feedback and it went poorly." If it's leadership: "When are you at your most effective as a leader?"

ASK WHAT THEY WANT, THEN DELIVER IT

In the first few minutes, ask: "What's most pressing on your mind about this topic?" Capture their answers, and reference them throughout the session.

PLAN TIGHT, HANG LOOSE

Know your material well enough that you can go with whatever comes up. Design the structure in advance, then adapt in real time based on what the room gives you. Leaders especially want to feel like you didn't come with a canned program.

PLANT QUESTIONS

Before the session, ask a partner you have a relationship with to ask a specific question during Q&A. It sounds small, but partners don't like to be outdone by their peers. One question from a colleague opens the floodgates.

This works best when it flows from a real relationship - another reason to invest in knowing partners as people, not just as your audience.

DON'T FORGET VIRTUAL PARTICIPANTS

If the program is hybrid, you're running three meetings: in-person, virtual, and bringing them together. Virtual attendees need a real way to participate - not just a screen showing the room. You'll lose them in 10 minutes if they're just watching.

END EARLY ON PURPOSE

Finish five to seven minutes before the scheduled end. Partners who get time back will come to the next one. One early finish buys more goodwill than a dozen on-time finishes.

USE THE CAPTIVE AUDIENCE

You've got them in the room. Find out what they'd want next. A one-question poll at the end - "what topic would bring you back?" - gives you the intel to plan your next program and makes them feel ownership over what comes next.

CONTRIBUTORS

Jon Krop · Founder and CEO, Flourish Legal Well-Being · jon@teamflourish.com

Manar Morales · Founder and CEO, DFA · manar@dfalliance.com

Aisha Greene · Deputy Chief Talent Officer – Americas, Hogan Lovells Cadwalader · aisha.greene@hlc.com